

Bryce Contreras

History 315

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Legacies of War Paper

Before taking this course, I generally thought of history as the study of an objective series of facts about the past. Historical events occurred at specific times, involved particular people, and had consequences that could be studied and understood. While I knew that people could disagree about history, those disagreements involved different opinions about the same set of facts. This course has changed that understanding by showing me that history is also shaped by perspective and memory. What individuals and societies remember, what they forget, and how they choose to tell stories about the past can influence how subsequent generations understand historical events. Memory is not perfect, and it can be filled with biases we may not have even known about or recognize.

This has important consequences for education, particularly in the social sciences. Teaching history should involve more than rote memorization of important names, dates, and events. I personally remember learning about the Spanish Armada in 1588. Without context, it has no meaning whatsoever. Students should not only learn what is important, but also why something is important, and learn about historical events from various perspectives. They should learn how historical narratives are created and whose perspectives are represented, and think critically about what was left out and the

reasoning behind the omissions. The readings in this course have shown me that history and memory are closely related and that societies that remember the past can influence our identities in the present. As a future educator, I want my students to understand that relationship while still recognizing the significance of evidence and facts. Through the various assignments, readings, videos, and other materials, I now possess a skill set to analyze what I read or consume more accurately, and I want my students to come to understand the same. With that said, I would assign them an inquiry-based lesson that asks them to investigate historical beliefs and narratives they have come to see as true in their own lives, dissect them, and assess whether those truths still hold on the other side. The goal would be for their understanding of history to change in the same way mine has.

One of the most important ideas I learned in this course is that history and memory are related, but not the same. Events can transpire, but the way people remember or interpret them can differ. Individuals, communities, or even entire nations can develop different understandings of the same past. Historical narratives are communicated and passed on through various media, including oral traditions, government institutions, books, and pop culture. These different sources influence perspective and why different versions of history exist and can compete with one another (Glassberg, 1996).

Previously, I never considered the curriculum I was fed while growing up in school. The thought that the Civil War or the Vietnam War could mean something

different to other people never occurred to me. For instance, to me, the Civil War was nothing short of the preservation of our Union and the freeing of slaves. It was a bloody conflict, but our nation came out better for it. However, that is not the entire truth. I never even knew about what had happened to Native American peoples during that same period of time, nor about the Lost Cause movement following the war.

The Lost Cause was the way in which the Confederate South interpreted and coped with the defeat in the Civil War. The Confederacy and its leaders were portrayed as honorable and heroic men who fought for their homeland rather than to preserve slavery (Vox, 2017). These ideas became embedded in public memory through the works of the United Daughters of the Confederacy (UDC), as they helped construct monuments, alter textbooks, and curate school curricula (Cox, 2003). As a consequence, their work shaped the future by helping raise and mold the segregationists of the Civil Rights Era.

Meanwhile, during the Civil War, there was the U.S. Dakota War of 1862. The narrative following the war, however, was largely focused on southern victimhood despite the Dakota people being murdered and driven from their homes. Public memory was largely focused on white folk while minimizing or excluding the experiences of the Dakota people (Legg, 2018). If one group's suffering becomes primary, the experiences of all others can be forgotten, which is largely the case here, as evidenced by the landscape and monuments constructed in places like Minnesota.

It is important to understand that one group's experiences should not be erased or replaced by another group's experiences, which is why true historical understanding requires multiple viewpoints. To achieve a more comprehensive understanding of the Civil War and the events that took place afterward, we must not only include the experiences of the victorious Union but also of the Confederate South, the African Americans, and the likes of the Dakota people, settlers, and any other group impacted by it. Looking at multiple perspectives does not require treating every historical claim as completely accurate, either. The facts are still important, and not everything is relative. Still, we should ask ourselves what evidence exists, whose experiences are represented, and whether or not important information or perspectives were excluded (deliberately or not).

These ideas have changed how I think history and the social sciences should be taught. Students need factual knowledge, of course, because they cannot think critically about events that have taken place if they do not know what happened. However, the simple memorization of facts should only be the beginning of their education. Students should learn to distinguish historical facts from historical memory. Facts are claims about the past that we support with evidence, such as citations. We also want our facts to come from reliable sources, which is why higher education takes source work so seriously. On the other hand, historical memory involves more than that. It involves how individuals and societies remember and interpret the past. Sometimes this may even involve forgetting specific aspects of the past. Historical fact and memory may overlap,

but discerning the differences can help students become better thinkers and develop a more complete understanding of history.

Historical narrative does not only come from professional historians; students encounter history through their families, communities, TV, movies, music, social media, etc. (Glassberg, 1996). Before a student even walks into a class, they already hold beliefs about the past without knowing why or where they originated. For that reason, I think it would benefit students to learn how to investigate historical narratives rather than simply learn the facts and either accept them as true or reject them. Certainly not everything we have learned is wrong, far from it. But students should learn to ask questions. Who created this? What evidence is there? What perspectives are included or missing? Why is this version of history being pushed, or why has it become so popular? What are the consequences of these beliefs? So on and so forth.

For my hypothetical lesson plan, I would prefer to teach a high school history class for this particular assignment. I think it could certainly involve ample writing and be done over the course of several weeks or months, or even serve as a semester paper. However, to keep things (relatively) brief and punctual, I could drive home the main points in a day or two, culminating in an assignment due at the end of the week. The main objective would be for students to understand how historical memory develops and to practice evaluating historical beliefs using evidence and multiple perspectives.

First and foremost, I would introduce a couple of basic concepts and terminology, including historical fact, historical interpretation, and historical memory, and give examples of each. For instance, I would introduce the Lost Cause as a case study, and students would learn how the UDC participated in shaping public memory of the Civil War or how it overshadowed the experiences of the Dakota peoples. The final part of the lesson would include an inquiry activity and a take-home assignment. Students would be asked to identify three beliefs or historical narratives they possess or have encountered. One shall be learned from family, another through school, and lastly one through society, social media, or otherwise. They will then be required to think and write about how they originally came to these beliefs and what evidence supports them. They will then be asked to go a little deeper and think about whose perspective is represented and whose is missing. Lastly, the students shall be required to write about how their understanding of the original beliefs has changed, if at all, due to their research.

This course has changed my understanding of history by showing me that studying the past involves more than establishing what happened. It also requires examining how people remember what happened, how historical narratives come to be, and why some perspectives are more influential than others. The readings on public memory, Lost Cause, the U.S Dakota War, remembrance, and personal memory demonstrated that the past continues to be interpreted differently by all of us.

References

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